



b. 1972 · American mathematician and author.

"Models are opinions embedded in maths."

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

O'Neil warns that opaque algorithms, deployed at scale, can entrench bias and harm while hiding behind a veneer of mathematical objectivity.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

A mathematics PhD who worked in finance and data science, she turned to exposing the social harms of poorly governed models, coining the idea of 'weapons of math destruction'.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

She anchors the Bias & Failure Modes Map in Unit 3's risk Slibrary and informs responsible-AI thinking throughout the course.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

Her work operationalises as auditing models for fairness, transparency and harm, and treating bias as a design and governance concern.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Her critique is sharper at diagnosis than prescription; operationalising algorithmic fairness remains technically and ethically contested.

ENDURING IMPACT

She helped launch the public conversation on algorithmic accountability that now shapes AI regulation and responsible-AI practice.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 3)

Nassim Nicholas Taleb · Giant 11

Andrew Ng · Giant 13

Roy Schwartz et al. · Giant 14

J.B. Quinn · Giant 15

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

O'Neil, C. (2016) Weapons of Math Destruction. New York: Crown.

Mehrabi, N. et al. (2021) 'A survey on bias and fairness in machine learning', ACM Computing Surveys, 54(6).